PRAYER SERIES AT TIFERET EYAL

# Communal Meditation: Why Do We Repeat the Amidah?

Prayer Series, Part 4

**Series:** Prayer Series (Tiferet Eyal, 2021-22) **Shiur:** Part 4 of the six-part Prayer Series, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom for Tiferet Eyal, Tuesday 21 December 2021

*These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.*

## Recap and Plan

The series so far: the history and theology of prayer (Part 1); the Siddur from Birkot HaShachar to Nishmat (Part 2); and the Shema and its blessings, creation, revelation and redemption (Part 3). After the winter break: the reading of the Torah in the service, including children and women reading.

Tonight: **the silent Amidah**, briefly, and then the main focus, **the repetition of the Amidah**. The Spanish and Portuguese have a unique custom of reciting an abridged repetition, half aloud and half silent, and other communities rely on it in pressing circumstances. The Rabbi wanted to trace where this comes from, how the customs evolved, and when one may rely on them.

## Part 1: The Four Names of the Amidah

Rabbinic literature has four names for the Amidah:

| Name | Meaning | Why |
|---|---|---|
| **תפלה** | *The* prayer | The Rambam always calls it simply *Tefillah*, because it **is** prayer: the centrepiece of every service |
| **עמידה** | Standing | The only part of the prayer where standing is **required** (standing at Baruch She'amar or Vayevarech David is only customary) |
| **שמונה עשרה** | Eighteen | The weekday Amidah's eighteen blessings |
| **תפלת לחש** | The silent prayer | The only part that **must** be said silently |

"We forget and we lose the centrality of the Amidah, because we have throughout the generations added so much onto the tefillah before and after." A thousand years ago Shacharit, Mincha and Arvit were simple: the Amidah, plus the blessings of the Shema morning and evening. "That's it."

## Part 2: Amidah: Standing Before the Shechinah

Why stand only here? Because everything until now is a warm-up. **This is when we stand face to face with the Shechinah.** That is the beauty of the Amidah: we pray together as a tzibur for the warm-up and the parts after, but here we try to forget everyone around us and imagine we are one-to-one with Hashem.

### No interruptions

- The **Mishnah in Berachot** says: even if a snake is wrapped around your ankle, you must not interrupt. The Gemara qualifies this: a snake that is not poisonous. (Today, of course, we would tell people to interrupt, "because we never know.") The point is hyperbolic: nothing may interrupt the Amidah. Not phones, and not gesturing to other people.
- Contrast the **Shema**: if someone greets you with "Shabbat shalom" in the middle of the first paragraph and it would be disrespectful to ignore him, you may respond or nod. In the Amidah, "you cannot do anything."

### Kavanah is indispensable

The Amidah is the only part of the prayer where **kavanah is *me'akev***, where lack of concentration invalidates it. The Gemara, the Rambam, and even the Shulchan Aruch rule that **if you prayed the Amidah without kavanah, you must repeat it.** "I repeat that. You have to repeat the prayer."

Why have we never heard of anyone doing this? The **Maharam of Rothenburg**, teacher of the Rosh in the thirteenth century, said that although this is the halachic requirement, he no longer advises it, because "probably the second time you're not going to have concentration either." This became accepted practice. But for the Shema, as long as you said the words you fulfilled the mitzvah; for the Amidah, strictly, you did not.

### Kavanah over standing

If the choice is between praying **sitting with kavanah** or **standing with less kavanah**, the halacha is clear: **concentration is more important.** So almost all contemporary poskim rule that **on a plane** you should not make a minyan in the back of the plane, with people walking around and disturbing you. Better to pray quietly in your seat.

### What kavanah means

There are two levels:

1. **The minimum, codified in halacha (the Rambam):** recognising that **you are standing before the Shechinah**, even if you don't understand every word. "For a few moments, I am now in conversation with the Divine. That is called kavanah."
2. **The better level:** understanding what you are saying.

This is why the verse **אדני שפתי תפתח** was added before the Amidah, which really begins with *Baruch Atah*. It gives a person a few moments to focus and set out on the journey of tefillah.

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## Part 3: Shemoneh Esreh: Eighteen, and the Nineteenth

The structure is **three blessings, then thirteen (or fourteen), then three**: eighteen, or nineteen. The eighteen were composed by the **Men of the Great Assembly**, about 2,400 years ago.

### The nineteenth blessing

was added in the **second century**, in response to the *minim*, the heretics: **ולמלשינים אל תהי תקוה** both the **Sadducees**, constantly fighting the rabbis, and the **Christians**, who believed Jesus was .the Mashiach

The Gemara says that **Rabban Gamliel** decided to institute the blessing. He stood in the Bet HaMidrash and asked who could formulate its text, and **Shmuel HaKatan** (not Shmuel the prophet) got up and composed it. Couldn't Rabban Gamliel compose a blessing himself?

**Rav Kook** answers with Pirkei Avot, where each of the Hachamim has his motto. Hillel used to say to greet people pleasantly. Shmuel HaKatan's motto was the verse **בנפל אויבך אל תשמח**, "When your enemy falls, do not rejoice." Rabban Gamliel needed someone who could compose this blessing **without any agenda, without personal hate**. He himself felt disappointment and strife with these people. Read the English of this blessing: uproot them, break them, shatter them. "It's very difficult to say these words in the modern era." Only someone who would never rejoice at his enemy's downfall could write it.

### Why eighteen?

The **Gemara in Berachot** gives three reasons:

| # | Eighteen corresponds to... |
|---|---|
| 1 | The **18 vertebrae** of the spine, because we bow during the Amidah. The halacha is to bend until you feel the vertebrae stand out: "you can't just nod your head" |
| 2 | The **18 mentions of Hashem's name in the Shema**, since we go straight from the Shema to the Amidah |
| 3 | The **18 mentions of Hashem's name in *Mizmor LeDavid, Havu LaShem*** (the psalm we say on Friday night), which also alludes to the Avot, around whom the Amidah centres |

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## Part 4: Tefillat Lachash: Learning From Hannah

The silent form of prayer is learned from **Hannah**. Barren for many years, she went to Shiloh, bitter and weeping, and prayed: **only her lips moved, and her voice was not heard**. Eli, thinking her drunk, confronted her: he had never seen anyone pray with moving lips and no sound. Hannah answered that she was not drunk, but a woman of sorrowful spirit.

Hannah taught the Kohen Gadol, and all generations, that **when you are close, you don't need to shout**. "Prayer ultimately is an intimate conversation, and no one else is meant to hear." We don't do the whole service this way, because we are a community, but the climax is quiet and intimate.

**But silent does not mean thinking.** "That's another misconception." The words must actually be **said**, to concretise one's thoughts. In yeshiva they were always encouraged to speak out what they learned with a study partner, because "even if you think you understand in your head, when you actually speak it out you concretise things." So too in the Amidah: we articulate the words, but quietly enough that others don't hear.

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## Part 5: Custom and Law: Feet and Steps

Everything binding in our religion must derive from the **Torah** or the **Gemara**. As the Rambam writes clearly, the Talmud, sealed in the fifth century, was the final vote of the Sanhedrin, our legislative body, and no one can argue with it. "Which is why I always make a point in all of my shiurim to always trace the origins of certain things which we do. Is it biblical? Is it rabbinic? Is it customary?"

**Which is more important: standing with the feet together, or taking three steps back before the Amidah?**

Rick answered correctly that the three steps are a custom. (Jane noted that the idea is approaching a king, which is indeed the idea, but the question is the source.)

| Practice | Source |
|---|---|
| **Feet together** | The **Gemara**: the angels have "a straight leg," and we put our feet together to resemble them. **Codified by the Rambam.** |
| **Three steps** | **Not in the Shulchan Aruch at all.** Recorded only in the **Rama**, for Ashkenazim, a late addition from the Ashkenazi Rishonim |

"If you ever want to know what's the *din* and what's extra, just look at the Rambam." On a plane you don't need to take three steps back.

### Forward, not back

The original custom was only to take **three steps forward**, approaching the Shechinah. If the whole synagogue stepped forward, the front row would hit the wall, so people began stepping back first and then forward. Some poskim were unhappy with this back-and-forth: "It looks like it's not respectful... you're playing a game here."

**The correct practice, which not many know:** take three steps back **earlier**, at **תהלות לאל עליון**, and then, when beginning the Amidah, step forward. Then at *Adonai sefatai tiftach* you have stepped forward and are in your place. The three steps back at the end are likewise a minhag, and the steps forward afterwards just return you to your place. Coming forward and going back express **intimacy, coming closer to the Shechinah**.

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## Part 6: Praise, Request, Thanksgiving

Every prayer has the same structure:

praise: the first three blessings (the God of our forefathers, who revives the dead, the holy **שבח**, God).

**בקשה**, request: the middle blessings.

**הודאה**, thanksgiving: the last three, from **רצה**.

"This is just basic derech eretz." When you write an email asking someone for something, you don't just ask; you begin by acknowledging them, perhaps thanking them for something they did, and end with thanks. So too: I address You because You are the source of all; then I ask; then I thank.

On **Shabbat** the rabbis removed the middle requests so as not to burden us, leaving a short Amidah, since Shabbat is not a time to stress about our weekday needs. "But obviously the Jewish people didn't want to accept that," and added plenty before and after.

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## Part 7: The Repetition of the Amidah

The Rabbi had spent considerable time researching this. "It's fascinating to see the different customs and how this all evolved."

### The original purpose

The **Mishnah in Rosh Hashanah** records a debate:

- **The Sages:** even though the shaliach tzibur prays, **everyone must still pray** for themselves.
- **Rabban Gamliel:** the shaliach tzibur can fulfil the obligation for everyone.

The Gemara explains that the halacha is a hybrid. **All year round, if you know how to pray, you must pray yourself**; the hazan's repetition is for those who cannot. On **Rosh Hashanah**, and on **Yom Kippur of the Yovel year** (which once every fifty years had very long special brachot), even those who know how to pray may rely on the hazan because the brachot are unfamiliar. This is the halacha in the Rambam and the Shulchan Aruch.

### Context: a world without siddurim

The Gemara must be read in context. When the Hachamim instituted the repetition there were **no siddurim**. The first siddur we have is that of **Rav Amram Gaon**, around the eighth or ninth century, in Babylonia. People knew the Amidah because their parents taught them, and not everyone could. So: those who know pray; those who don't listen to the hazan.

But as siddurim spread and people became proficient readers, in the early medieval period people began to ask: "Why are we doing things twice?" That might have been enough to abolish the repetition.

### The complication: Kedushah

At the same time another minhag was developing. The **Yerushalmi**, quoted by **Tosafot** in a couple of places, records that originally **Kedushah was said only at Shacharit on Shabbat and Yom Tov**. In the time of the Geonim it spread to **every prayer with a repetition**. And saying Kedushah in unison with ten people is a **Torah mitzvah**, to sanctify Hashem's name. Abolish the repetition and you lose the Kedushah.

Two conflicting pressures: on the one hand, people can read and no longer need a repetition; on the other, without a repetition there is no Kedushah. "So different methods came up through the generations to try to address these issues."

### Method 1: Rav Hai Gaon: three blessings and stop

The earliest approach the Rabbi knew of is **Rav Hai Gaon** (tenth century), quoted by the **Beit Yosef**. When it is getting late and the sun is setting: everyone prays the silent Amidah, then the hazan repeats **only the first three blessings with Kedushah**, through **האל הקדוש**, and stops.

Remarkably, **the Shulchan Aruch records this as acceptable** when time is short. "It's quite striking: we can take an Amidah instituted to be eighteen blessings, and just do three blessings to do Kedushah." But it never caught on. Rav Hai Gaon describes it as the custom in the

Babylonian yeshivot, when a late shiur ran into Mincha at sunset. Since then it is scarcely recorded. "I've never seen this done... It just feels you're stopping mid-air."

### Method 2: The Rambam: one Amidah, aloud

The Rambam's approach: **no silent Amidah at all**. The hazan says the whole Amidah aloud, with Kedushah. Those who know how to pray say it quietly along with him; those who don't, listen. There is just one prayer, no repetition.

The Rabbi showed two of the Rambam's responsa (**Teshuvot HaRambam 256 and 258**), offering to send them afterwards. "The problems which we have in each generation are the same problems." The Rambam describes his reasons:

- During the repetition people **chat with one another and go out**, and the hazan's blessings go unanswered.
- Even Torah scholars use the time to talk, and apparently to clear their throats and noses.
- The uninitiated person sees this and concludes the repetition is a waste of time, when he is the one who needs it most because he can't read.
- The Rambam calls it a **chillul Hashem**, applying the verse **עת לעשות לה׳ הפרו תורתך**: "It's become a joke."

So the Rambam made his **takkanah**: on **Shabbat and Yom Tov, at all the prayers**, because so many people come, and at **Mincha when time is short**, the hazan says one Amidah aloud.

His son, **Rabbeinu Avraham**, writes that because of his father's takkanah this became the practice **throughout Egypt**. "And unfortunately, nothing has really changed since the Rambam's time. Exact same thing happens today."

**The Radbaz**, Rabbeinu David ben Zimra (1479-1573, as Jane looked up), chief rabbi of Egypt and author of over two thousand responsa, writes that everyone in Egypt still did this because of the Rambam, more than 350 years later. He was unhappy and tried to restore the original takkanah, pointing out that in **Aleppo**, **Damascus**, and among Jews who came from **Aden**, they did a repetition. Whether he succeeded, the Rabbi did not know. He had read that some **Yemenite** communities, who accepted the Rambam in almost everything, still keep one loud Amidah today, though he had never seen it.

### Method 3: The Spanish and Portuguese: aloud, silent, aloud

The method many know:

1. The hazan says the **first three blessings aloud**, with **Kedushah** together.
2. The **middle blessings are silent**, for everyone, including the hazan.
3. The hazan says the **last three blessings**, from **Retzeh**, aloud.

The **Radbaz** saw this in some places and suggested it grew out of the Rambam's method: a hazan who leads every prayer aloud never gets a chance for *lachash*, to pour out his own words silently to Hashem. The silent middle gives him that space.

**Advantages:** besides Kedushah, you get **Modim DeRabbanan** (under the Rambam's method the hazan says Modim aloud while everyone says it with him, so there is never the congregation's own Modim), and the hazan can include **Birkat Kohanim**. **Hacham Shem Tov Gaguine**, in the **Keter Shem Tov**, the Spanish and Portuguese authority about a hundred years ago, favoured it for these reasons, and writes that he saw it only in **London and Amsterdam**.

**The problem:** "I'll be honest, I'm not a big fan of this custom." After the silent middle, the hazan comes back in while some people are ahead and others behind. People are disturbed and don't know where he is up to. "I can't tell you how many times people have asked me, if I'm in the middle of Amidah, do I need to respond?"

The Rabbi suspects (without proof) that originally the hazan said the middle part **very slowly**, giving everyone time to finish before resuming. When he leads without a repetition and there is time, he always draws out the middle blessings for exactly this reason.

**The halacha:** respond to the hazan's last blessings **only if you have finished your Amidah**. If you are still in the middle, you may not respond to anything, not even amen.

### When was this done?

There are two reasons for a shortened repetition: **lack of time**, or **people making a mockery of the repetition** when crowds come on Shabbat and Yom Tov.

- The original Spanish and Portuguese practice was to do this at **Musaf on Shabbat and Yom Tov** (after a long sermon and long parashah, people anxious to leave and chatting) and at **weekday Mincha** (people at work and busy).
- Doing it at **Shacharit** is, to the Rabbi's understanding, **only from the last twenty or thirty years**, because often there are only ten people.
- "I humbly suggest on Sundays or bank holidays, when we have the time and we have ample minyan, not just ten exactly, there's no reason why we shouldn't do repetition."

### Method 4: The Ashkenazi custom

When Ashkenazim are short of time, **only the hazan** begins the Amidah aloud. Everyone listens and answers *Baruch Hu uvaruch Shemo*, amen and Kedushah. When he reaches **HaEl HaKadosh**, the whole community begins the silent Amidah together. The drawback: no Modim DeRabbanan and no Birkat Kohanim.

"Every method has its advantages. Every method has its disadvantages." They all evolved from the same tension: the repetition no longer seems needed, yet we have Kedushah, Modim DeRabbanan and Birkat Kohanim.

### The kabbalistic view

According to the **kabbalists**, all this is futile. The repetition has nothing to do with people who can't read; it is about moving "from one world to the next," and so on. For them **one must always repeat the Amidah**, however busy one is. The shiur did not take that approach, but it explains why some people always insist on a repetition.

**The takeaway:** don't make a mockery of the repetition. No talking, no chatting, no walking in and out. Listen, pay attention, and answer amen and *Baruch Hu uvaruch Shemo*.

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## Questions at the End

**Adam: isn't petition the most self-regarding part, as if there were "a technology" for getting God to answer? Isn't the main thing awareness of standing before God?** Petition isn't pressing God's buttons, the Rabbi said (as in the first shiur). Its purpose is to recognise that Hashem is the source of our wisdom, wealth and health, and that recognition brings intimacy. "Petition isn't a means in itself. It's a means to an end of the intimacy with the Divine." Can you

ask for something very specific? "Of course. On the contrary, we must ask for everything," like the son who should have asked his father rather than his uncle. Asking purely out of devotion, with no hope of reward, is the highest level, but "almost impossible." The Hachamim instituted petition because it is close to our hearts: "people listen to things when it's relevant to their lives... The Rambam probably got there, but I don't think anyone else gets there."

**Rick (from the choir): why do we answer *Baruch Hu uvaruch Shemo* sometimes and not at others?** If you are relying on the hazan to fulfil your obligation, you never answer *Baruch Hu uvaruch Shemo*. And if you haven't finished your own Amidah you can't answer anything, not even amen ("If there's a snake around your ankle, you can't say amen, can you?"). In the Spanish and Portuguese Musaf, the silent middle gives you time to finish, which is why the hazan should go slowly, so that from Modim you can respond.

**Gabriel: on Rosh Hashanah we need to hear 101 tekiot. How, without a repetition?** Exactly. That's why Rosh Hashanah is different: every community in the world does a full repetition on Rosh Hashanah, without fail.

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## Summary

1. **Four names:** Tefillah (the Rambam's name: it *is* prayer), Amidah, Shemoneh Esreh, Tefillat Lachash.
2. **Amidah:** face to face with the Shechinah. No interruptions (the snake). **Kavanah is indispensable**: strictly one repeats without it, but since the **Maharam of Rothenburg** we don't. Kavanah outranks standing (pray seated on a plane). Minimum kavanah: knowing you stand before the Shechinah.
3. **Eighteen blessings** from the Men of the Great Assembly; the **nineteenth** by **Shmuel HaKatan**, chosen (Rav Kook) because he never rejoiced at an enemy's fall. Eighteen = vertebrae, names in Shema, names in *Havu LaShem*.
4. **Silent, from Hannah**, but the words must be spoken.
5. **Feet together** is Gemara and Rambam; **three steps** is a late Ashkenazi custom (Rama). Originally only steps forward; step back at *Tehillot LeEl Elyon*.
6. **Structure:** praise, request, thanksgiving.
7. **Repetition:** instituted for those who couldn't pray, in a world without siddurim; preserved because of **Kedushah**. Four methods: **Rav Hai Gaon** (three blessings and stop, in the Shulchan Aruch but never adopted); **the Rambam** (one loud Amidah, against the mockery of the repetition; all Egypt for centuries until the Radbaz; reportedly still some Yemenites); **Spanish and Portuguese** (first and last three aloud, middle silent; gives Modim DeRabbanan and Birkat Kohanim; hazan must go slowly; don't respond mid-Amidah); **Ashkenazi** (hazan aloud to HaEl HaKadosh, then all begin). Kabbalists always repeat.
8. **Don't make a mockery of the repetition.**

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## Coming Up

After the winter break, **Tuesday 11 January**: the **reading of the Torah**, its origins as a takkanah, and **children and women reading from the Torah**.

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